imperialism' and fostering a sense of solidarity with Asian and African countries. With the end of their entente, India partnered primarily the Soviets against China, though the US was briefly an ally in the 1962 war. By 1969, India and China found themselves more firmly embedded on opposite sides of the Cold War, a situation that was to last until 1988. The second period, the post–Cold War, goes from 1989 to the present. It began, as in the Cold War, with an India–China entente against American hegemony. By 1999, however, India had come together increasingly with the US against China. And by 2009, India and China were more firmly on opposite sides of a new global Cold War, this time between the US and China.

At least three conclusions stand out across these two periods. First, India and China have both partnered the USSR/Russia and the US. The idea that China is a shrewd operator in international politics and that it cleverly combines with others is a widely shared view, one that garners admiration all round. India by contrast is seen as a strategic innocent and is routinely derided for its supposed aversion to partnerships. In fact, though, it has a continuous history of opportunistic partnering in the interest of its security.

Second, the main target of India's partnerships has been China. Its principal big-power partner against China was the USSR, but briefly in the 1960s and increasingly after 1999 it has relied on the US to balance Chinese power. On the other hand, China's partnerships with the Soviets, the US, and later Russia have not been directed against India, primarily because the Chinese feel they can deal with India more or less on their own (with some help from Pakistan).

Third, except for two brief periods of entente when they feared and resented the US, India and China have always been on opposite sides in terms of their partnerships. This has meant that they must deal with an added layer of suspicion and competition in their relationship. It has also meant that they have no history of working closely together, of building a stock of strategic knowledge and trust between them. With such a stock, they might have dealt with mutual conflicts differently.